Preface. This volume was assembled to test how a reader keeps its place. Every sentence here was written for the fixture and carries no outside text. The front matter uses roman numerals so that the printed label never equals the physical page.

Acknowledgements. The author thanks the patient pages that agreed to be rotated, cropped, split into columns and scanned without complaint. Their cooperation made the measurements possible.

Contents. One, the pond in winter. Two, the heron at the inlet. Three, the ledger of small things. Four, what the lamp showed. Appendix, notes on the method.

The pond in winter keeps its own counsel. Under a skin of grey ice the water still moves, slowly, turning over the cold it gathered in the night. A walker who stops at the shore hears it settle.

Snow lies in the reeds like paper folded and forgotten. The light arrives late and leaves early, and in between it is careful, touching each stone as if it were counting them.

The heron at the inlet waited without moving for the length of a long breath. Its patience was not idleness; it was attention held so steadily that the fish forgot it was there.

When it struck, the water closed over the place so quickly that the ripple seemed to come first. Then the bird stood as before, and the inlet resumed its quiet business.

The ledger of small things records what nobody else will: the first frost on the pump handle, the day the wrens left, the hour the stove went out and the room stayed warm anyway.

Kept faithfully, such a ledger becomes a map of attention. It shows not what happened in the world but what a person was willing to notice, which is a different and more useful history.

What the lamp showed was only the table, the open book and the edge of a hand. Beyond that circle the room existed by memory alone, and memory furnished it generously.

Reading by such a light, one learns that a page is a place. It has a top and a bottom, a margin to write in, and a particular line where the eye returns after looking up.

Appendix. Notes on the method. Each page of this fixture was generated by a small script so that the words, their positions and the page labels are known in advance and can be checked exactly.